Will Yatras Be Charting a New Path? Why Not?

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News of the Bharat Jodo Yatra did not come from any of the official networks of the Congress party, but rather from Digvijaya Singh (the former chief minister of Madhya Pradesh), with whom we share a close personal equation. Given we have all been actively involved in grassroots activism, we understand the multiple hardships—logistical, personal, psychological and, most of all, political—that any yatra imposes on an individual and an organization. And rather than thinking about possible outcomes or benefits, our first thoughts were intensely personal. Given our ties with Digvijaya Singh, some of our colleagues quipped with concern, 'Will Raja-Saab (indicating Digvijaya Singh) walk from Kanyakumari to Kashmir at this age?' To which someone else promptly responded, 'Why not? He completed the Narmada Parikrama with fervour and good spirit.' While we were still weighing the multiple challenges the Yatra posed, on 1 August (August Kranti Day), Digvijaya Singh reached out to Dr G.G. Parikh and many of us civil society activists with a personal invite from Sonia Gandhi to join in the Yatra. The invite emphasized that it wasn't the Congress party's yatra, but one of and by the people. That reassured all of us outside formal political organizations.

While we were thinking about the modalities of joining the Yatra, I was reminded of the situation in 1930. Mahatma Gandhi launched the Dandi March with just a handful of people, eschewing opposition even from within the Congress party. He instinctively understood that the nation needed mass mobilization to escalate the struggle against the undemocratic British Raj. Despite the Congress party not understanding the importance of